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Faculty of Humanities

Zaheer Ul Islam

Term Paper

Social Media Persuasion in Tourism: Linguistic Strategies in Facebook and Instagram Tourism Advertisements – A Critical Discourse Analysis

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Email: zaheerulislam885@gmail.com

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ABSTRACT

This study employs critical discourse analysis (CDA), guided by Fairclough's (2001) three-dimensional model, to investigate persuasive linguistic strategies in tourism advertisements on Facebook and Instagram. Drawing on a corpus of 60 English-language advertisements (30 from each platform) from global brands, collected between September and November 2025, the analysis identifies micro-linguistic features across phonetic, lexical, grammatical, stylistic, and pragmatic levels. Results indicate platform-specific patterns: Facebook advertisements adopt a transactional style, utilizing imperatives, urgency-inducing lexicon, and direct calls to action to elicit immediate user responses. In contrast, Instagram advertisements favour an aspirational discourse, incorporating metaphors, sensory imagery, and implicatures to establish emotional engagement and idealized traveller identities. These strategies not only capture attention and enable persuasion but also perpetuate neoliberal ideologies of consumerism, framing travel as a commodified pathway to status and self-fulfilment. The research advances applied linguistics by illustrating CDA's effectiveness in dissecting digital media persuasion. It provides marketers with insights into platform-optimized communication and enhances media literacy to mitigate manipulative practices. Broader implications underscore the importance of ethical advertising in algorithm-mediated tourism environments, urging future explorations of AI-influenced discourse.

Keywords: critical discourse analysis, social media advertising, tourism discourse, linguistic persuasion, Facebook, Instagram, applied linguistics, neoliberal ideologies

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Chapter-I

Introduction

Language serves as a potent tool for shaping perceptions, emotions, and behaviours, particularly in advertising where strategic word choices can influence consumer decisions subtly yet profoundly (Fairclough, 2001; Gee, 2011). In the realm of tourism, this persuasive power is amplified on social media platforms, which have revolutionized how destinations are marketed and consumed (Thurlow & Jaworski, 2011). With over 5.66 billion users engaging daily (Statista, 2025), Facebook and Instagram represent key arenas for global brands to deploy linguistic strategies that attract attention and drive bookings. However, existing research often prioritizes visual semiotics or broad marketing tactics. It underexplores the micro-linguistic features phonetic, lexical, grammatical, stylistic, and pragmatic that underpin persuasion in these digital spaces (Manca, 2016; Qian et al., 2018).

This oversight forms the core problem. While social media's role in tourism is well-documented, the ideological functions of language in constructing persuasive messages remain underrealized. This is especially true in comparative platform contexts. For instance, imperatives may foster urgency on Facebook, whereas metaphors evoke aspiration on Instagram. Yet, their interplay with power dynamics like consumerism and neo-colonial exoticism warrants deeper scrutiny (Du & Cheong, 2025), which examines TikTok but overlooks Facebook-Instagram comparisons. Recent studies on social media CDA, such as analyses of influencer posts on Instagram, highlight multimodal elements. However, they rarely extend to tourism advertising's linguistic strategies across platforms (Tobias-Mamina et al., 2020; Thakur & Sharma, 2025). This study addresses this gap by employing Fairclough's (2001) three-dimensional CDA model to examine how linguistic strategies in tourism advertisements persuade users and sustain broader ideologies.

The research questions are: (a) What are the predominant platform-specific persuasive linguistic strategies in tourism advertisements on Facebook and Instagram? (b) How do these strategies function to attract user attention and facilitate persuasion in platform-specific contexts? (c) In what ways do these strategies reflect and reinforce ideologies of consumerism and power in digital tourism discourse?

The objectives align accordingly: (a) to identify and compare these strategies, (b) to analyse their persuasive functions, and (c) to examine their ideological implications. A qualitative CDA approach was employed to analyse advertisements from global brands.

The study's significance lies in advancing applied linguistics by demonstrating CDA's applicability to digital persuasion. It offers marketers platform-tailored insights and promotes media literacy to counter manipulative discourses in tourism. These contributions pave the way for the methodology outlined in the following section.

Chapter-II

Literature Review

The literature review synthesizes key theoretical and empirical works on discourse, discourse analysis, and their applications to tourism and social media advertising. It begins with foundational concepts of discourse as a social practice, progresses to specialized forms such as tourism discourse, and examines methodological approaches including discourse analysis (DA) and critical discourse analysis (CDA). The review then contextualizes these within media and advertising discourses, particularly in digital platforms like Facebook and Instagram. Finally, it outlines the theoretical framework and highlights the literature gap this study addresses.

Discourse as Social Practice

Discourse extends beyond mere communication, functioning as a powerful social force that shapes thoughts, emotions, actions, and power relations (Fairclough, 2001). In this view, language is not neutral but actively constructs social realities, maintaining or challenging ideologies. Fairclough (2001) emphasizes that discourse reflects and reproduces power dynamics, particularly in globalized contexts like the internet and social media. This perspective is crucial for analysing tourism advertisements, where language and visuals shape consumer desires and establish advertiser authority, often reinforcing neoliberal consumerism.

Complementing this, Gee (2001) links discourse to cognitive and identity-building processes through "cultural models" shared, implicit beliefs that interpret texts and experiences. In tourism contexts, these models evoke ideals like "escape" or "adventure," enabling advertisements to resonate persuasively; however, Gee's framework critiques how such models can perpetuate stereotypical identities without addressing power imbalances as robustly as Fairclough does. Building on this, Gee (2011) distinguishes "discourse" (language-in-use) from "Discourse" (socially recognized identities), illustrating how ads invite users to adopt roles such as the "cosmopolitan traveller." Van Dijk (2013) adds a sociocognitive layer, arguing that discourse relies on unspoken shared knowledge, which tourism ads exploit by implying exclusivity or relaxation without explicit elaboration, though this approach sometimes overlooks multimodal elements in digital media.

Scollon and Scollon (2003) introduce geosemiotics, positing that meaning depends on context, extending from physical to digital environments. On social media, an ad's significance emerges from platform features like algorithms, hashtags, and user interactions, amplifying persuasion. Together, these theories frame discourse as social action, identity formation, shared knowledge, and contextual practice, essential for dissecting persuasive strategies in digital tourism campaigns. Nevertheless, they require integration with recent empirical studies to address platform-specific dynamics, as explored in subsequent sections.

Types of Tourism Discourse

Tourism discourse represents a specialized genre that commodifies places and experiences, blending information with persuasion (Dann, 1996; Thurlow & Jaworski, 2011; Manca, 2016). Dann (1996) describes it as seductive and controlling, persuading audiences while shaping behaviours through selective portrayals. In social media, this translates to "seduction" via attention-grabbing posts and "control" by guiding perceptions of destinations, positioning tourists in a learner-like role; however, Dann's model, rooted in pre-digital media, underexplores interactive user responses.

Thurlow and Jaworski (2011) highlight "banal globalization," where tourism discourse appropriates local cultures into stylized symbols of authenticity, often masking simplification. This is evident in social media's use of hashtags and visuals to commodify "exotic" elements for global audiences, critiquing how such practices reinforce cultural stereotypes. Manca (2016) emphasizes multimodality, where persuasion arises from text-image interplay, such as sensory adjectives complementing visuals in ecotourism ads, providing a bridge to digital adaptations.

Recent studies extend this to digital contexts. For instance, research on overtourism mitigation through sustainable branding analyses anti-spring break campaigns, revealing how discourse counters negative tourism impacts by rebranding destinations to attract responsible visitors (Spezzano & Lusby, 2024). Similarly, a study on organic destination imagery in China's Greater Bay Area maps tourism dynamics via social media, underscoring multimodal evolution; however, it prioritizes visual mapping over linguistic granularity, limiting insights into persuasive text strategies (Lei et al., 2025). These works affirm tourism discourse's adaptation on social media, blending traditional persuasion with interactive, visual formats, but often prioritize broad marketing over micro-

linguistic scrutiny. This limitation underscores the need for methodological tools like DA and CDA to delve deeper into linguistic mechanisms.

Discourse Analysis

Discourse analysis (DA) provides tools to examine language as social action, particularly in digital contexts (Gee, 2011; Jones, 2024; Tannen et al., 2015; Page et al., 2022; Myers, 2009). Gee (2011) views DA as studying language to "do things," such as building brand images in ads, though it could better incorporate algorithmic influences. Jones (2024) addresses technologically mediated discourse, offering methods for platforms like Instagram. Tannen et al. (2015) stress contextual language use, while Page et al. (2022) guide social media analysis, tackling ethical data issues. Myers (2009) explores participatory platforms, relevant for interactive ad features.

This integrated DA approach shifts from defining tourism discourse to analysing its persuasive mechanisms in digital environments, incorporating text-visual synergy and user engagement, setting the stage for critical extensions through CDA.

Critical Discourse Analysis

CDA uncovers hidden power and ideologies in communication, treating discourse as a tool for social critique (Fairclough, 2023; Machin & Mayr, 2023; Qian et al., 2018). Fairclough (2023) defines CDA as critical social analysis, linking discourse to power and ideology reproduction, ideal for unpacking consumerism in ads. Machin and Mayr (2023) provide a multimodal framework for digital texts, analysing how visuals and language normalize ideologies like consumer entitlement, advancing beyond text-only approaches.

In tourism, Qian et al. (2018) affirm CDA's utility for destination marketing, revealing stereotypes and unsustainable practices, though their review predates widespread social media shifts. Recent applications include CDA of sustainability discourses on platforms like Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram, showing how they shape ideological narratives; yet, it focuses more on environmental themes than platform-specific linguistic persuasion (González-Reverté, 2025). Another study explores audio-visual discourse in ASEAN tourism videos, critiquing how media reflect or challenge practices, but underexplores textual pragmatics in interactive ads (Liu, 2025). This critical lens positions tourism ads as shapers of cultural and social realities, yet few apply it comparatively to platform-specific linguistics. Extending this critique, the

following section examines media discourse to highlight digital ecosystem influences.

To summarize key theories and their applications, the following table outlines major contributions:

Theory/Scholar	Key Concept	Application to Social Media Tourism Ads	Limitations in Context of This Study
Fairclough (2001, 2023)	Discourse as power and ideology	Analyzes how ads reinforce consumerism via linguistic strategies	Requires empirical extension to digital platforms
Gee (2001, 2011)	Cultural models and identities	Explains identity-building in aspirational Instagram posts	Overlooks multimodal power dynamics
Van Dijk (2013)	Sociocognitive discourse	Highlights implicit knowledge in persuasive captions	Underexplores visual-text interplay
Scollon & Scollon (2003)	Geosemiotics	Contextualizes ad meaning in algorithm-driven feeds	Limited focus on interactive features
Dann (1996)	Seductive and controlling discourse	Applies to attention-grabbing Facebook promotions	Pre-digital; ignores user co-creation
Thurlow & Jaworski (2011)	Banal globalization	Critiques cultural commodification in hashtags	Needs update for 2025 algorithm shifts

Manca (2016)	Multimodal persuasion	Bridges text and visuals in ecotourism ads	Prioritizes broad strategies over micro-linguistics

Media Discourse in Digital Contexts

Media discourse encompasses language practices in digital ecosystems, influencing tourism persuasion (Cotter, 2015; Thurlow, 2018; Georgalou, 2017; Page, 2015; Zappavigna, 2011; Tagg et al., 2017; Vásquez, 2014; Bou-Franch & Blitvich, 2018). Cotter (2015) notes the shift to interactive users, making ads co-created through engagement. Thurlow (2018) analyses dimensions like materiality (e.g., algorithms) and ideologies (e.g., consumerism), highlighting socio-technical influences.

Georgalou (2017) and Page (2015) explore identity and narrative on platforms, where ads craft tourist stories. Zappavigna (2011) introduces "ambient affiliation" via hashtags, building communities. Tagg et al. (2017) and Vásquez (2014) highlight interaction norms and evaluations.

Recent insights on 2025 algorithm changes emphasize engagement prioritization in tourism strategies. For instance, Instagram focuses on saves and shares for micro-influencers to boost aspirational content. In contrast, Facebook's AI-driven push favors short-form videos and conversations for transactional interactions (StackInfluence, 2025; CrowdRiff, 2025). A case study on Valencia's Instagram tourism account underscores user engagement in attraction (Gómez-Quijano & Carrasco-Santos, 2025). These dynamics frame ads as embedded in socio-technical systems, critiquing how algorithms amplify ideological biases, which ties directly into advertising discourse.

Advertising Discourse in Tourism

Advertising discourse persuades through structured, multimodal strategies (Cook, 2001; Fuertes-Olivera et al., 2001; McQuarrie & Phillips, 2014; Manca, 2016; Tobias-Mamina et al., 2020; Zhang, 2006). Cook (2001) describes ads as creating "parallel worlds" linking products to lifestyles. Fuertes-Olivera et al. (2001) and Zhang (2006) detail linguistic features like metadiscourse and imperatives for covert persuasion.

McQuarrie and Phillips (2014) advocate rhetorical analysis for deviations like metaphors. Manca (2016) applies this to tourism, balancing authenticity and idealization. Tobias-Mamina et al. (2020) empirically link Instagram ads to visit

intentions, contrasting aspirational storytelling on Instagram with more transactional calls-to-action on platforms like Facebook, highlighting platform-specific adaptations.

Storytelling in social media enhances destination branding, integrating photos, videos, and text for engagement (Shafieizadeh et al., 2025). These insights reveal advertising's adaptation to digital tourism, though empirical studies often overlook comparative linguistic strategies across platforms. This sets the foundation for the study's theoretical framework.

Theoretical Framework

This study adopts Norman Fairclough's three-dimensional model of Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) as its primary theoretical framework. CDA examines language as a social practice that constructs power, ideologies, and identities (Fairclough, 2001). It aligns with the topic of social media persuasion in tourism. Tourism advertisements on Facebook and Instagram use linguistic strategies to persuade users and attract attention. Fairclough's model provides a structured way to analyse these strategies. It links micro-level language features to broader social effects, such as promoting consumerism and idealized travel experiences.

Fairclough's CDA variant suits this research best. It offers three interconnected dimensions: text, discursive practice, and social practice. This approach connects linguistic details to ideological persuasion, unlike van Dijk's focus on cognitive models or Wodak's emphasis on historical contexts (Machin & Mayr, 2023). In tourism discourse, it uncovers how ads build desires for luxury and adventure, and it reinforces globalized consumer identities (Thurlow & Jaworski, 2011). Fairclough's emphasis on ideological persuasion is particularly apt for social media, where linguistic strategies interact with visuals and algorithms to commodify tourism experiences (Thurlow & Jaworski, 2011). For example, CDA excels in revealing platform affordances, such as how Instagram's visual emphasis enables aspirational persuasion, while Facebook's algorithmic urgency drives transactional responses (Fuad Nasvian et al., 2025). The framework integrates seamlessly with the study's aims. It identifies linguistic strategies at phonetic, lexical, grammatical, stylistic, and pragmatic levels. It also explains how these strategies enable persuasion on digital platforms like Facebook and Instagram. The following subsections detail these dimensions, illustrating their application to linguistic strategies in social media tourism campaigns.

Dimension of Text (Description): The Micro-Linguistic Analysis

The text dimension describes the linguistic properties of advertisements. This study adapts it to five micro-linguistic levels. These levels reveal how language persuades and captures user attention in tourism ads. These levels consider text-visual interplay, as linguistic strategies often complement images to persuade users (Machin & Mayr, 2023). The table below summarizes the levels with examples tied to tourism contexts.

Level	Description	Example	Persuasive Function
Phonetic	Sound patterns boost memorability.	Alliteration in "Tropical Treasures Await" creates rhythm and appeal in Instagram feeds (Gee, 2011).	Enhances aesthetic draw in fast-scrolling environments, reinforcing aspirational ideologies through multimodal synergy.
Lexical	Word choices evoke urgency and relatability.	Colloquial expressions like "save BIG" build connections, and hashtags act as neologisms to create online communities (Zappavigna, 2011).	Fosters emotional bonds and community affiliation, promoting consumerist desires.
Grammatical and Syntactic	Sentence structures drive action.	Imperatives like "Book now!" command responses, and parallelism provides emphasis and flow (Fuertes-Olivera et al., 2001).	Prompts immediate user engagement, driving transactional persuasion.
Stylistic	Figurative devices stir emotions.	Metaphors such as "a beach like paradise" and hyperbole heighten desires for perfect travel moments (Manca, 2016).	Amplifies aspirational imagery, idealizing tourism experiences.

Pragmatic	Implied meanings shape interactions.	Directives prompt bookings, and presuppositions assume user interests to make persuasion subtle.	Softens commercial intent through implicatures, such as in hashtags implying exclusivity and luxury.

Building on textual analysis, the next dimension explores production and consumption in social media contexts.

Dimension of Discursive Practice (Interpretation): Production, Distribution, and Consumption

The discursive practice dimension interprets text creation and use. It accounts for social media contexts. Advertisers design language for user engagement, and they employ hashtags for wider distribution (#Wanderlust increases visibility). Consumption occurs through user responses; Facebook's algorithmic priority on urgency encourages transactional persuasion, while Instagram's visual emphasis supports aspirational narratives (Qian et al., 2018). Algorithms also amplify multimodal elements, where visuals enhance linguistic persuasion in tourism promotion (Du & Cheong, 2025). This dimension highlights platform differences, such as how algorithms amplify persuasive reach in tourism promotion (Fuad Nasvian et al., 2025).

Dimension of Social Practice (Explanation): Ideology and Power

The social practice dimension explains wider implications. It ties language to societal ideologies. Tourism ads advance consumerism as a route to fulfilment, and they position tourists as privileged explorers. For example, ads portraying "undiscovered" destinations reinforce tourist privilege, perpetuating global power imbalances and neo-colonial "exoticism" (Thurlow & Jaworski, 2011). This upholds social inequalities in global travel, as seen in modernistic representations in social media tourism content (Alharbi, 2022). Recent critiques, such as multimodal CDA of sustainable imaginaries on social media, further illustrate how these ideologies shape digital tourism narratives (Du & Cheong, 2025).

Synthesis: Integrating the Dimensions for a Holistic Analysis

The three dimensions form an integrated whole. Textual elements inform discursive practices, and these practices mirror social ideologies. This framework examines linguistic strategies in tourism ads. It shows how they persuade users,

form identities, and support consumerism on social media. This holistic approach accounts for multimodal interactions, revealing how linguistic and visual strategies sustain tourism consumerism. Applied to the corpus, this framework reveals how linguistic strategies on Facebook and Instagram sustain tourism consumerism.

Literature Gap

Despite advances, research on tourism discourse prioritizes visual elements and broad marketing over micro-linguistic strategies (Manca, 2016; Qian et al., 2018). While recent studies address social media's role in tourism geographies and marketing (Moyle et al., 2024; Antonio et al., 2024), few apply CDA comparatively to Facebook and Instagram advertisements, underexploring phonetic, lexical, grammatical, stylistic, and pragmatic features in platform-specific contexts (e.g., algorithm-driven persuasion). For instance, Antonio et al. (2024) examines sentiment in tweets but overlooks micro-linguistic features in ads, further highlighting the need for comparative CDA. This oversight limits understanding of how such strategies reinforce ideologies of consumerism and power imbalances, which this study addresses through Fairclough's model applied to a corpus of 60 ads from these platforms.

Chapter-III
Methodology

This chapter outlines the methodological approach employed in the study. It ensures transparency and replicability in line with qualitative research standards in applied linguistics (Creswell & Poth, 2018). The design is qualitative, and it is grounded in Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) to examine linguistic persuasion in social media tourism advertisements. The chapter details the research design, sampling technique, inclusion and exclusion criteria, data analysis procedure, and analytical tools. It also addresses ethical considerations to uphold integrity in analysing public digital content.

3.1 Research Design

The study adopts a qualitative research design. This design is appropriate for exploring the nuanced ways discourse constructs meanings in tourism advertisements (Fairclough, 2001). The approach facilitates an in-depth examination of linguistic strategies and their persuasive functions. It aligns with CDA's emphasis on interpreting language within social contexts, and it enables the investigation of how advertisements on Facebook and Instagram shape user attention and ideologies. The qualitative nature prioritizes descriptive depth over quantification, and it focuses on a corpus of 60 advertisements to uncover platform-specific patterns (Page et al., 2022). This design leads naturally to purposive sampling for targeted data selection.

3.2 Sampling Technique

A multistage purposive sampling strategy was utilized to select relevant data. In the first stage, Facebook and Instagram were chosen as platforms due to their prominence in tourism advertising and multimodal content. These platforms offer rich textual and visual data for CDA (Georgalou, 2017). In the second stage, official pages of global brands, such as airlines (e.g., Qatar Airways) and tourism organizations (e.g., Discover Pakistan), were selected based on high engagement defined as posts with over 500 likes or shares and English-language posts. In conclusion, purposive sampling ensures targeted, relevant data. By focusing on persuasive content from influential sources, this technique enables comparison between platforms. The sampling connects to inclusion and exclusion criteria for data consistency.

3.3 Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

Inclusion criteria were established to maintain consistency. Posts must originate from official global tourism brand pages, be in English, contain analysable textual elements like captions, and demonstrate persuasive intent. All selected advertisements were publicly available and published within a three-month timeframe (September to November 2025). Exclusion criteria omitted non-English content, purely visual posts, user-generated comments, and material from unofficial or personal accounts. In conclusion, these criteria ensure a focused corpus. They delimit data to high-quality, brand-created advertisements, supporting CDA examination of linguistic persuasion. These criteria lead to the data analysis procedure for systematic examination.

3.4 Data Analysis Procedure

Data analysis followed Fairclough's (2001) three-dimensional CDA model to connect linguistic properties with social practices. Initial close reading identified persuasive features across phonetic, lexical, grammatical, stylistic, and pragmatic levels. The discursive practice dimension interpreted production and consumption, considering platform algorithms and user interactions. The social practice dimension explained ideological implications, such as consumerism. Analysis was manual, with systematic annotation to categorize features and themes. In conclusion, this procedure provides a layered examination. It reveals how linguistic strategies persuade users and sustain power in digital tourism (Machin & Mayr, 2023). The procedure relies on analytical tools for thematic organization.

3.5 Analytical Tools

Given the dataset's manageable size, analysis relied on manual close reading and annotation, supplemented by tools like NVivo for thematic coding where needed. No automated software was used for primary analysis to preserve interpretive nuance, but potential biases were mitigated through cross-verification, reflexive notes, and NVivo's audit trails (Bazeley & Jackson, 2013). In conclusion, manual methods ensure detailed scrutiny. These tools support qualitative depth in CDA and facilitate examination of persuasion (Gee, 2011). They also uphold ethical considerations in data handling.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

Ethical guidelines were followed, as the data consisted of publicly available advertisements from official pages, requiring no informed consent (Page et al., 2022). Brand names were anonymized where appropriate to avoid bias, and the analysis respected fair use principles while considering potential cultural sensitivities in global content, such as avoiding misrepresentation of "exotic" destinations in digital contexts. In conclusion, ethics prioritize transparency and fairness. These considerations ensure responsible research by upholding integrity in critiquing digital persuasion.

Chapter-IV

Analysis and Findings

This chapter presents the analysis and findings from a corpus of 60 tourism advertisements 30 from Facebook and 30 from Instagram collected from official pages of global brands such as Pakistan International Airlines (PIA), Qatar Airways, Discover Pakistan, National Geographic Travel (@natgeotravel), and Lonely Planet (@lonelyplanet). Published between September and November 2025, these ads were selected for their English-language content and persuasive intent. They focus on themes like discounts, destinations, and experiential travel. The analysis applies Norman Fairclough's (2001) three-dimensional model of Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) holistically. It examines discourse as text (micro-linguistic features at phonetic, lexical, grammatical, stylistic, and pragmatic levels), discursive practice (production and consumption in platform contexts), and social practice (broader ideologies of power and consumerism). Rather than isolating dimensions, this integrated approach reveals how linguistic strategies interweave with platform affordances to persuade users. It shapes desires and reinforces neoliberal ideals of travel as commodified escape and status. By linking micro-level language to macro-social effects, the findings highlight platform-specific persuasion: transactional urgency on Facebook versus aspirational identity-building on Instagram.

Analysis of Facebook Advertisements

Facebook tourism ads typically adopt a promotional, offer-driven format. They leverage the platform's algorithm for targeted reach and immediate engagement. At the textual level, micro-linguistic features create urgency and direct action. For instance, in a PIA ad promoting a "Massive 50% Discount" on flights to Saudi Arabia (#PIA50Off), phonetic elements like alliteration in "Massive... Make... Make" and consonance with hard /k/ sounds in "KSA," "Class," and "BIG" produce a rhythmic, assertive tone. This enhances memorability and commands attention. Lexically, evaluative adjectives such as "massive" and "affordable" combine with colloquialisms like "save BIG" and branded hashtags (#EidWithPIA, #SaudiSavings) to foster relatability and community. Grammatically, imperative moods dominate—"Book now," "Enjoy seamless travel"—paired with active voice and parallelism (e.g., "Fly from Pakistan to Riyadh, Al Qassim and Dammam"). This compels users to act swiftly.

Stylistically, hyperbole ("mind-blowing natural wonders") and sensory imagery ("breathtaking beauty of northern Pakistan") paint idealized escapes. Pragmatically, directives presuppose user desires (e.g., framing discounts as solutions to affordability), employing politeness strategies like offers as "gifts" ("Enjoy 10% off").

These textual choices are interpreted through discursive practices, where production exploits Facebook's features like headlines, bullet points, and "Book Now" buttons for paid promotions targeting demographics interested in travel deals. Consumption is interactive, measured by likes, shares, and comments, with urgency-driven language ("Seats are filling fast") boosting engagement metrics. For example, a Qatar Airways partnership ad with IHG Hotels & Resorts, posted on November 20, 2025, uses imperatives in the caption "Qatar Airways has signed a partnership with IHG Hotels & Resorts to launch a series of initiatives for business travel" to align with the platform's algorithmic preference for quick-response content. This amplifies visibility through user shares and integrated loyalty benefits.

Explained at the social practice level, these strategies reflect and reinforce ideologies of consumerism. They position travel as a purchasable commodity accessible "just one click away." Advertisers wield power by framing luxury as affordable (#SaudiSavings), blending family values with commerce (e.g., "reconnect with loved ones" for Eid flights), and commodifying destinations as tourist playgrounds. This perpetuates neoliberal power imbalances, where global brands like PIA and Qatar Airways dominate narratives, marginalizing local voices in favour of consumer privilege.

Analysis of Instagram Advertisements

In contrast, Instagram ads emphasize aspirational narratives through high-quality visuals and captions, fostering emotional connections. Textually, phonetic patterns like assonance in "alone cloud daydreaming" (@travelbeautifulpakistan) create lyrical softness matching serene images. Lexically, evaluative adjectives ("stunning alpine valley," "raw beauty") and hashtags as bundles (#NorthernPakistan, #WanderlustPakistan) evoke feelings and identity. Grammatically, declaratives build authority ("Pakistan is home to 5 of the 14 highest peaks"), rhetorical questions engage ("Which one will you choose?"), and parallelism structures choices (e.g., "From the elegance of Place Vendôme to..."). Stylistically, metaphors ("Yosemite of Pakistan") and hyperbole ("makes the

travel well worth it," @natgeotravel) dominate, with sensory imagery ("blooming gardens, golden sunsets") vividifying experiences. Pragmatically, assertive describe destinations, expressive convey enthusiasm, and softer directives ("Plan your escape") imply lifestyle elevation via implicature.

Discursively, production prioritizes "Instagrammable" aesthetics, where captions complement visuals in carousels or Reels, optimized for algorithms rewarding likes and saves. Consumption is co-creative, with users sharing and commenting to extend narratives. A Lonely Planet post on "BEST IN TRAVEL 2025," shared on October 23, 2024, and extending into 2025 promotions, uses questions in the caption "BEST IN TRAVEL 2025 is HERE 30 destinations that inspire..." to spark interaction, enhancing discoverability through hashtags (#Wanderlust).

Socially, these practices promote aspirational consumerism, defining "beautiful" and "authentic" travel as markers of status. Power dynamics emerge in external representations (e.g., Pakistan as "undiscovered"), echoing neo-colonial discovery narratives. Brands like Meliá Hotels frame luxury as identity ("Shall we meet there?"), stratifying access and reinforcing tourist privilege over host communities.

Synthesis of Findings

Across platforms, Fairclough's model illuminates how micro-linguistic strategies urgent imperatives on Facebook versus evocative metaphors on Instagram function within discursive practices shaped by algorithms and user interactions. Ultimately, they sustain social ideologies of commodified travel. Facebook's transactional discourse drives immediate consumption, while Instagram's aspirational style constructs idealized identities, both perpetuating power imbalances in global tourism. These findings extend CDA to digital spaces, revealing language's role in normalizing consumerism amid 2025's algorithm-driven landscapes. They also carry implications for sustainable tourism, urging ethical linguistic practices that challenge commodification and promote equitable representations.

Chapter-V

Discussion

This chapter interprets the findings from the critical discourse analysis (CDA) of 60 tourism advertisements on Facebook and Instagram, linking them to the research questions and objectives. It begins by restating the key results, then compares them to existing literature, discusses theoretical and practical implications, addresses limitations, and suggests directions for future research. The discussion underscores how platform-specific linguistic strategies not only persuade users but also perpetuate broader ideologies of consumerism and power in digital tourism discourse. It highlights the need for ethical interventions in an era of evolving algorithms.

Interpretation of Findings

The analysis revealed distinct persuasive linguistic strategies tailored to each platform's affordances and user expectations. This directly addresses the research questions on predominant strategies, their functions in persuasion, and their ideological reinforcements. On Facebook, advertisements employ a transactional style. They are characterized by imperatives ("Book now"), urgency-creating lexicon ("save BIG," "limited-time offer"), and direct calls to action. These features align with Fairclough's (2001) textual dimension. Here, micro-linguistic elements like alliteration and hyperbole generate immediate responses. In contrast, Instagram ads adopt an aspirational approach. They use evocative metaphors ("Yosemite of Pakistan"), sensory imagery ("blooming gardens, golden sunsets"), and rhetorical questions to build emotional connections and ideal traveller identities. This emphasizes stylistic and pragmatic layers for deeper resonance.

These strategies function to attract attention and facilitate persuasion within platform-specific contexts. This responds to the first and second research questions. Facebook's algorithmic emphasis on quick engagement rewards transactional urgency. It drives clicks and bookings through presuppositions of affordability and value. For instance, the platform's preference for short-form, interactive content amplifies directives. This turns passive scrolling into active consumption. Instagram's visual focus, meanwhile, amplifies aspirational narratives. It fosters "ambient affiliation" (Zappavigna, 2011) via hashtags like #Wanderlust. These encourage saves, shares, and community building. At Fairclough's (2001) social practice level, both platforms reinforce consumerism. Facebook commodifies travel as a deal-driven transaction. Instagram positions it

as a lifestyle marker. Both perpetuate power imbalances where global brands dominate representations of "exotic" destinations, often at the expense of local agency.

Comparison with Previous Literature

The findings support and extend prior scholarship on tourism and advertising discourse. They confirm the adaptability of linguistic strategies in digital environments. The transactional urgency on Facebook echoes Cook's (2001) concept of "parallel worlds." Here, ads construct deal-driven realities through imperatives and metadiscourse, as detailed by Fuertes-Olivera et al. (2001). This aligns with Zhang's (2006) analysis of stylistic features in advertising. Elliptical syntax and evaluative adjectives create immediacy, now amplified by platform algorithms. Similarly, Instagram's stylistic dominance resonates with Manca's (2016) multimodal persuasion. Metaphors and sensory language are optimized for visual feeds. This builds on Zappavigna's (2011) ambient affiliation in fostering consumer communities.

Critically, the platform comparison advances Qian et al.'s (2018) CDA review. It applies Fairclough's model to underexplored micro-linguistics in digital ads. This reveals how algorithms shape ideological reinforcement—a gap in Thurlow and Jaworski's (2011) banal globalization framework. Recent studies corroborate these hegemonic critiques. For example, a 2025 multimodal discourse analysis of sustainable tourism imaginaries on TikTok shows how short-form videos blend visuals and text to promote eco-friendly narratives. Yet, while insightful, it often overlooks linguistic power dynamics similar to those identified here. Likewise, research on digital discourses of sustainability across social media platforms emphasizes framing theory in urban tourism marketing. But it under examines comparative linguistics between Facebook and Instagram. Overall, the results affirm CDA's relevance in digital environments (Machin & Mayr, 2023). They extend it to 2025's algorithm-driven persuasion. Here, updates like Instagram's enhanced Reels prioritization favour aspirational content over transactional posts.

Implications

Theoretically, this study validates Fairclough's (2001) framework for multimodal social media analysis. It bridges applied linguistics with tourism studies. It demonstrates how micro-features interconnect with macro-ideologies. This enriches understandings of digital persuasion and highlights CDA's utility in critiquing algorithm-mediated discourse.

Practically, the findings inform tourism marketers. Employ direct, value-focused language on Facebook for conversions. Use narrative-driven styles on Instagram

for engagement. For instance, amid 2025 algorithm shifts prioritizing authentic interactions, brands should integrate user-generated content to boost reach. This is evident in emerging trends for destination marketers. Building on Facebook's urgency, marketers should test AI-optimized posts for higher conversions. Educators can incorporate these insights into media literacy curricula. This fosters critical awareness of persuasive discourse. Broader societal implications highlight the need for ethical advertising. By challenging commodification, stakeholders can promote sustainable tourism and equitable representations. This counters power imbalances amplified by algorithms that favour global brands over local voices.

Limitations

This qualitative study is limited to 60 English-language ads from major brands. It potentially overlooks smaller operators or non-English content. The manual analysis, while nuanced, lacks inter-coder reliability measures. Focusing on brand text excludes user comments, which could influence co-created meanings. Future quantitative extensions could address these.

Future Research

Future studies could apply CDA to multilingual ads or emerging platforms like TikTok. They should incorporate user-generated content and AI-influenced algorithms. Longitudinal analyses of algorithm changes—such as Meta's 2025 updates reshaping engagement—or experimental designs testing persuasion effects would further validate these findings. Additionally, exploring sustainability-focused campaigns could examine how linguistic strategies promote ethical tourism.

In conclusion, this study illuminates the sophisticated role of language in social media tourism persuasion. By deconstructing platform-specific strategies, it reveals their ideological underpinnings. These advances applied linguistics and calls for responsible digital discourse in an increasingly algorithm-dominated landscape.

Conclusion

This study deconstructed the mechanics of persuasion in social media advertisements for travel and tourism by investigating linguistic strategies on Facebook and Instagram through Fairclough's (2001) three-dimensional model of Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA). It has offered a nuanced understanding of how these strategies capture attention, shape desires, and persuade users. This chapter summarizes the key findings, reaffirms the study's contributions, and reflects on the broader implications of this discourse.

The objectives were to identify and compare platform-specific persuasive linguistic strategies, analyse their functions in user persuasion, and examine their ideological roles. A qualitative design analysed 60 advertisements 30 from each platform from global brands, guided by Fairclough's (2001) framework of discourse as text, discursive practice, and social practice.

Findings highlighted tailored strategies: Facebook's transactional approach with imperatives ("Book now"), lexical urgency ("Massive 50% Discount"), and value presuppositions; Instagram's aspirational discourse via metaphors, evocative lexicon ("pristine," "breathtaking"), and lifestyle implicatures. Socially, both commodify travel as a neoliberal pathway to fulfilment and status, naturalizing the "ideal tourist" and reinforcing consumption-driven power.

Theoretically, this validates Fairclough's model in digital contexts, bridging applied linguistics, tourism, and media studies by elucidating language-power dynamics in algorithm-mediated genres.

Practically, it guides marketers in platform-optimized messaging transactional for Facebook conversions, aspirational for Instagram engagement while advocating ethical practices to counter commodification.

In summary, social media tourism advertisements transcend selling destinations; they craft dreams and lifestyles, shaping global perceptions of travel. This discourse demands reflection on exploration's cultural meanings, positioning audiences as active participants in value-laden conversations. Every linguistic element, from hashtags to imperatives, serves deliberate persuasion.

Extending these implications, future research should probe AI-generated content's potential to entrench or challenge these ideologies, ensuring CDA evolves with automated digital landscapes

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